

STANDING STRONG

FOR NORTHERN IRELAND

The DUP Manifesto
for the 2017 Westminster Election





Leader's Message

The General Election gives unionism the chance to get back on the right track. Be in no doubt, the party that has most Members of Parliament elected will be seen as the voice of Northern Ireland. The Prime Minister's decision to hold a snap poll provides a basis to make the positive case for the Union.

At this election, we seek a mandate for the Union that really matters – the Union with Great Britain – to make sure Northern Ireland gets the best Brexit deal and to reach an honourable and not a one sided deal to get the Assembly up and running again to deal with the real problems that are faced by people in their everyday lives.

The choice at this election is clear. If you want unionism to be strengthened then you should unite around the strongest unionist party.

A vote for DUP candidates is the strongest unionist vote.

Now, more than ever, unionism needs to speak with one voice.

Make no mistake, elections matter. On this occasion our votes may not be required to help form a government at Westminster but the implications for politics in Northern Ireland could not be greater.

What we need is a mandate for unionism, for a deal to get Northern Ireland back on track and for the restoration of the Assembly and Executive.

How people vote at this election and how many seats we have will determine not just individual Members of Parliament but the shape and direction of our country thereafter.

Unionism needs its strongest team.

Northern Ireland needs one strong unionist voice leading from the front to protect our place in the union and to get the best deal for Northern Ireland.

We are that voice.

We are proud to be standing strong for Northern Ireland.

Rt Hon Arlene Foster MLA
Leader, Democratic Unionist Party



Deputy Leader/Parliamentary Party Leader's Message

This Westminster election comes at a time of great importance for our country and for Northern Ireland. For the first time in decades, the powers of Parliament will grow. This growth means its importance to the lives of each and every one of us grows too. This makes it vital that we have a strong, united and clear voice to speak up for Northern Ireland.

We need a 'Team Northern Ireland' on the benches of Westminster. Only the DUP offers the people of Northern Ireland the team that can maximise our influence. No other party will be large enough to break through and ensure Northern Ireland's voice is heard loud and clear.

Our job will not be to refight old battles, the people have spoken. It is our job to use our mandate and our influence to get the best deal for Northern Ireland on the issues that matter like the Budget and leaving the EU.

In the previous parliamentary term, the DUP team used its influence, in public and private, for the benefit of people in Northern Ireland. For example, the fight to save working tax credits protected the incomes of 100,000 people here. We also used the previous term to develop positive working relationships that the DUP is committed to building on in the next term.

On 8th June, a vote for the DUP team is a vote to send 'Team Northern Ireland' to Westminster. It is a team that has real influence and experience in speaking up for the interests and needs of Northern Ireland. It is this team and this party that is working and delivering for local people.

At this election, we re-dedicate ourselves to doing it again.

Rt Hon Nigel Dodds

Deputy Leader, Democratic Unionist Party

1 Restoring Devolution Now

The Democratic Unionist Party believes that Northern Ireland needs a working Assembly and Executive as the best form of government for all of our people.

Stormont is far from perfect but it is immeasurably better than what happened before or what would replace it. The progress we have made should not be easily cast aside to be replaced by uncertainty with power transferred to unaccountable Direct Rule Ministers.

There are 5 pressing reasons why we need devolution restored immediately.

• **To help achieve the best deal for Northern Ireland as the UK leaves the EU** – at precisely the time when Northern Ireland's voice needs to be heard loudly and clearly the Northern Ireland Executive has not been formed. If we are to deal with the challenges and seize the opportunities that leaving the European Union presents then we need our own local Ministers lobbying London and Brussels.

• **To get a Budget put in place** – Northern Ireland is in uncharted territory where senior Civil Servants are making public spending decisions and not elected politicians. Sinn Fein's Finance Minister left post without proposing a Budget. Key public services and – most importantly – the people who rely on them, need a Budget to be set so they can get the support they need.

• **To progress much needed health reforms** – our National Health Service faces unprecedented pressures. The DUP kick started much needed reforms aimed at creating a new model of health and social care and reducing bureaucracy and streamlining structures. Those reforms are now effectively on hold with challenges like waiting lists mounting. People should not have to wait any longer to have those reforms implemented and problems tackled.

• **To protect and improve our education system** – the impact of not having an Executive in place is already being felt across our school system. Having an Executive up and running is critical to resolving the funding crisis facing our schools thus ensuring that we prioritise frontline funding for our schools so that all our children receive the best educational start in life. It is vital that we build on positive practical reforms in education.

• **To attract investment and jobs** – it is no coincidence that our record levels of inward investment have happened during a sustained period of devolution. Having stable structures at Stormont with local Ministers leading efforts to sell Northern Ireland internationally has helped us secure thousands of new jobs. Without devolution, all of the efforts to reduce our rate of Corporation tax will have been for nothing. Political stability is key to our future economic success.

THE STRONGEST, MOST EXPERIENCED UNIONIST TEAM READY FOR NEGOTIATIONS

Immediately after the General Election, we will enter another round of negotiations. The DUP will place the interests of the people of Northern Ireland first in those negotiations. We will not draw any red lines or put any roadblocks in the way of seeing an Executive formed straight away.

It is absolutely imperative that voters use this election to not only send a clear message that they want to see Stormont restored but also give unionism the strongest possible hand in the talks. No other Party has the strength, unity or experience of delivering for unionism that the DUP possesses.

Unionists remember what it was like in the past when Sinn Fein were able to advance their radical republican agenda in negotiations, aided and abetted by weak unionists. This all changed when the DUP started to lead unionism. Since 2003, the DUP has slowly but surely regained ground for unionism culminating in the Stormont House and Fresh Start Agreements.

Sinn Fein have sought to use their mandate at the last Assembly election to block the re-establishment of the Assembly, to demand a destabilising Border Poll and to push their agenda. It's time for unionists to come out and vote so the real voice of Northern Ireland is heard. The DUP needs a strong mandate to stand strong against Sinn Fein's demands.

Immediately after the election on 8 June the negotiations aimed at restoring devolution will recommence with a view to establishing a new Executive by 29 June.

We will enter these negotiations with a positive approach and a goal of seeing the Assembly and Executive restored.

We will not draw any red lines or preconditions but will judge any potential deal against 5 core tests.

1. Is the agreement likely to increase support for Northern Ireland's constitutional position within the United Kingdom?

2. Is the agreement fully consistent with Northern Ireland remaining a full and integral part of the United Kingdom?

3. Is the agreement fully compatible with our British citizenship?

4. Will the agreement result in better government and policies for the people of Northern Ireland than a return to Direct Rule?

5. Is the agreement consistent with the mandate we received for our Assembly manifesto in March?

For ease of reference we set out the 10 commitments for negotiations which were endorsed on 2 March.

OUR 10 COMMITMENTS IN NEGOTIATIONS

1. We will work to avoid Direct Rule and get local government back at Stormont as quickly as possible.
2. Our demands in negotiations will be proportionate to those of Gerry Adams and Sinn Fein.
3. As has been the case since 2007, we remain committed to working constructively and in partnership with all those who are in an Executive after an election.
4. We will respond positively to any proposals to increase transparency, accountability and will help the institutions function more effectively.
5. We will not compromise on fundamental unionist principles in order to retain power.
6. We will not permit the rewriting of the past or the persecution of the security forces.
7. We will oppose any Border Poll outside the terms of the Belfast Agreement.
8. We will stand over those proposals for reform as set out in our 'Making Stormont Work Better' document which have not yet been delivered.
9. We will work to ensure the full implementation of the Military Covenant in Northern Ireland.
10. We will honour all previous commitments we have made on the basis that republicans will honour theirs as well.

2 Increasing Family Incomes

Our national and local economy has been improving steadily over the last number of years. Indeed, Northern Ireland is performing better in some aspects than the rest of the UK. The DUP believes that it is essential that the benefits of economic growth are felt by everyone, everywhere. An improving economy must not just be for the benefit of big companies or confined to London and the South East. Growth must also have a meaningful and positive impact on the lives of hardworking families in every part of our nation.

We welcome the fact that median gross weekly earnings for full-time employees increased by 2.2% in Northern Ireland last year. That made it the second consecutive annual increase in inflation adjusted earnings in the region. We want to see continued improvement in earnings and incomes.

We understand that it will be the responsibility of the Party that forms the next Government to bring forward a Budget that encourages economic growth and protects our society's most vulnerable. The DUP proposes measures aimed at increasing family incomes that we seek to have included in future Budgets.

1. INCREASE THE NATIONAL LIVING WAGE

The newly introduced National Living Wage (NLW) has helped increase family incomes across the United Kingdom. Whilst acknowledging the pressures that the NLW can place upon small businesses, the DUP believes that it can have a positive impact on working families, help lift people out of poverty and make work pay.

The DUP supports:

- Continued increases in the National Living Wage; and
- Firm action against companies who fail to pay their staff the NLW.

2. FURTHER INCREASE THE PERSONAL TAX ALLOWANCE

The DUP were frontrunners in proposing increases in the personal tax allowance. We firmly believe that the gradual increase in the personal tax allowance has been positive for all taxpayers but especially for the lowest paid, taking them out of the tax system entirely, and hugely beneficial for thousands of people from Northern Ireland. In Parliament, we will support proposals to further increase the personal allowance.

3. FREEZE THEN CUT OR ABOLISH THE TV LICENCE AND REFORM THE BBC

The TV licence fee is a highly regressive tax which was designed for a different era and a world of communication that no longer exists. The success of Netflix and Amazon streaming services shows that subscription based media can and does work.

An independent Commission should be established to conduct a review of how the BBC is structured and the services it provides and to examine alternative funding models, identify the opportunities for competitive tendering of key services and produce a plan that will either significantly reduce the licence fee or abolish it.

4. PROTECTING PENSIONS

The DUP has always advocated for the interests of our older people. In the Northern Ireland Executive, we have introduced initiatives like free bus passes and have defended their retention against those who would take them away. We will continue our staunch support for pensioners in the new Parliament.

The DUP will:

- Support the maintenance of the pensions 'triple lock'; and
- Support an end to the unfair treatment of women pensioners.

5. AFFORDABLE ENERGY

Paying for oil, gas and electricity can consume a significant chunk of household budgets. A perception exists that electricity prices in Northern Ireland are high. Whilst prices are undoubtedly high for the largest industrial customers, our approximately 800,000 domestic customers pay just below the EU average for their electricity and considerably lower than their counterparts in the Republic of Ireland.

The DUP wants to see our energy companies place further downward pressure on household bills. We will support efforts to better control energy bills and will seek to ensure any such measure operates in Northern Ireland.

6. SAFEGUARDING UNIVERSAL BENEFITS

The DUP is proud of the universal benefits we have introduced in Northern Ireland like free public transport for the over 60s. Some parties have once again placed universal benefits like the winter fuel allowance in their sights. The DUP will resist any assault on these important universal benefits.

3 Creating a Globally Competitive Economy

Northern Ireland's economy – like the rest of the United Kingdom's – is heading in the right direction. Key economic indicators show sustained progress across a range of important areas:

- Our unemployment rate and economic inactivity levels have fallen significantly since their peak during the downturn;
- Growth of 1.6% in the last year driven by the private sector;
- Spending on Research & Development rose by 24% last year to £750 million – an all time high;
- Exports by Northern Ireland companies increased by 6% in the past year – the highest increase of any UK region;
- Manufacturing sales increased by 6% in the last year and jobs in the sector grew by 1.4%; and
- External visitor numbers increased by 12% to 2.6 million.

We are determined to build on that success and continue the positive development in our economic fortunes. This is our plan for the Northern Ireland economy.

1. MORE AND BETTER PAYING JOBS

Northern Ireland has experienced falling unemployment, increased job creation and record levels of inward investment. Between 2011 and 2016:

- 42,500 new jobs were promoted
- 64% of those new jobs were outside of Belfast
- £3 billion of employment related investment was secured

The DUP wants to build on that outstanding success by:

- Reaffirming our pledge to create 50,000 new jobs by 2021;
- Implementing the Economic Inactivity Strategy; and
- Reducing Northern Ireland's Corporation Tax rate to at least 12.5%.

2. AN INDUSTRIAL RENAISSANCE IN NORTHERN IRELAND

Northern Ireland has a rich industrial heritage. The DUP wants to build on our strong manufacturing base and encourage a renaissance in Northern Ireland industry.

The DUP supports the delivery of an ambitious new Industrial Strategy for Northern Ireland which is aimed at increasing our competitiveness and ensuring inclusive growth. A Northern Ireland Industrial Strategy must be aligned to the wider UK Industrial Strategy and be centred on:

- Accelerating innovation and research;
- Enhancing education, skills and employability;
- Driving inclusive, sustainable growth;
- Succeeding in global markets; and
- Building the best economic infrastructure.

While some seek to talk Northern Ireland down we see huge potential in our economy. Northern Ireland has world class capabilities in sectors such as cyber security, agri-foods, advanced engineering and materials handling. By taking a long term, ten years plus view, we can become a globally competitive economy built upon a renewed and reinvigorated industrial base.

We will also continue to press HM Government to create City Region Growth Deals for Northern Ireland.

3. SELLING NORTHERN IRELAND TO THE WORLD

Increasing exports and improving trade links will play a huge part in Northern Ireland's economic future. While Northern Ireland has been the best performing region for exports in the whole of the United Kingdom, we must build on that success and begin the groundwork needed to capitalise on the trade opportunities that the UK leaving the EU will present. That's why the DUP introduced an International Trade Plan which included:

- a new Trade Advisory Board;
- the appointment of Northern Ireland Trade Ambassadors;
- the expansion of Invest NI's international presence in up to 10 more locations;
- the creation of new trade, investment and innovation hubs in key global markets; and
- a Trade Accelerator Plan including an enhanced range of initiatives to help support both new and existing exporters to explore new markets

The DUP supports the roll out of the International Trade Plan and we will ensure that the new Department of International Trade works closely with Invest NI to, for example, include more local companies in UK wide trade missions to help them develop international business opportunities.

We will lobby Her Majesty's Government to:

- help market Northern Ireland internationally through its agencies and embassies across the world;
- establish a Freeports policy targeted at economically underdeveloped parts of the UK
- encourage international events to be staged in Northern Ireland; and
- continue to incorporate Northern Ireland prominently in UK branding.

4. MAKING TOURISM A £1 BILLION INDUSTRY

Northern Ireland has developed hugely in recent times as a must visit destination for visitors from around the world.

The DUP supports the development of a new Tourism Strategy for Northern Ireland to take the industry here to a new level and reach our full potential. A Tourism Strategy should:

- Introduce a Capital Investment Fund for the development of new tourism products;
- Create a Tourism Development Fund to support the growth of tourism businesses with an export potential;
- Establish a Market Access Fund to encourage businesses to participate in marketing activity;
- Set a target of 3,000 new hotel beds; and
- Establish a new Air Routes Task Force.

We will also pursue:

- The abolition of Air Passenger Duty; and
- A cut in the VAT rate for tourism businesses.

5. A SECURE AND SUSTAINABLE ENERGY SUPPLY FOR NORTHERN IRELAND

Northern Ireland needs a secure and sustainable energy supply for both domestic and business customers. While concerns have been highlighted about the future security of supply of electricity in Northern Ireland, the DUP believes that this can be addressed by continued progress on interconnection, market integration and the development of new generation capacity. We are encouraged by recent planning applications for new power stations and see this as a sign that the market is responding positively and that the issues with security of supply can be addressed.

The DUP also believes that a comprehensive new Energy Strategy is needed to deal with security of supply as well as the future of renewable energy policy in Northern Ireland.

The DUP supports:

- A comprehensive new Energy Strategy for Northern Ireland;
- Continued progress on the Integrated Single Electricity Market and the North South Interconnector;
- Improved interconnection with Great Britain; and
- The development of new generation capacity.

6. MAKING NORTHERN IRELAND THE BEST PLACE TO DO BUSINESS

Northern Ireland is already a great place to do business. Whether it is a start-up or an inward investor, Northern Ireland offers companies a lower cost base, loyal and skilled workers and sensible regulation. The DUP wants to build on that hard-earned reputation and make Northern Ireland not just a good place but the best place to do business.

We will support:

- Keeping the cost of doing business low by maintaining Industrial De-Rating and the Small Business Rates Relief;
- Reducing the rate of Corporation Tax to at least 12.5%;
- Introducing a new Better Business Initiative that will systematically review health and safety legislation working in concert with sectors such as construction;
- the maintenance of the present workers' rights framework and for the UK to lead the way in improving this framework as it has throughout its history;
- UK wide tax policy improvements to encourage economic growth in Northern Ireland; and
- Assistance from HM Government to attract FDI into Northern Ireland.

7. SECURING THE SKILLS TO SUCCEED

A strong skills base has been a substantial element to Northern Ireland's recent economic success. In an increasingly competitive global economy, it is often the skills and talents of our people that positively differentiate Northern Ireland from other possible investment destinations. Investment in skills must continue if Northern Ireland is to continue to secure jobs and investment.

The DUP supports:

- Further investment in job focused skills schemes like Assured Skills and Future Skills to provide potential investors and existing employers with the skilled workers they need to grow;
- A digital skills revolution in our schools, colleges and universities to enable young people to become digital citizens, digital workers and digital makers, ready for the modern economy;
- Continued delivery of the reformed apprenticeships and youth training systems;
- Efforts to deliver a better deal for NI business from the Apprenticeship Levy;
- Increased involvement of industry in shaping the skills agenda; and
- Better alignment of third level courses with the strong and emerging sectors of our economy.

8. KEEPING NORTHERN IRELAND WELL CONNECTED

Investment in infrastructure is crucial for economic competitiveness as well as providing a boost for the local construction industry. Given Northern Ireland's geographical location, improved digital and transport connectivity remain key to building a world class economy.

The DUP will:

- Support expansion at Heathrow as the UK's aviation hub with increased air connectivity to Northern Ireland;
- Seek an independent investigation into ferry price structures on North Channel and Irish Sea routes between Northern Ireland and Great Britain;
- Develop a comprehensive Broadband Infrastructure Plan to roll out high speed internet connectivity across Northern Ireland;
- Continue to press the mobile telephony providers to invest in their networks ensuring 4G provision across Northern Ireland and that we are at the forefront of future 5G investments; and
- Establish the new Northern Ireland Infrastructure Fund as quickly as possible.

4 Improving Public Services

The DUP has a track record of positively reforming public services and streamlining the political system. Due to our determination, we have delivered:

- a reduction in the number of Government Departments from 12 to 9;
- a reduction in the number of Special Advisors;
- a reduction in the number of MLAs per constituency from 6 to 5; and
- a reduction in the number of Councils from 26 to 11.

The DUP has also been the driving force behind a series of public sector reforms which are aimed at developing a more effective and more efficient government. These include:

- a Civil Service Voluntary Exit Scheme yielding annual savings of approximately £100 million;
- a Public Sector Reform Architecture including the NI Public Sector Innovation Laboratory; and
- a suite of internationally renowned Shared Services which have saved the public purse hundreds of millions of pounds in reduced office, IT, procurement and energy costs.

Reforming public services is not solely about realising efficiencies so that Northern Ireland can live within its means. It is also about delivering a more effective public sector and freeing up resources to be spent on priorities like schools, hospitals and policing.

The DUP wants to continue to reform our public sector. This is our Plan to improve public services in Northern Ireland.

1. A NATIONAL REFORM PLAN FOR NORTHERN IRELAND

The DUP believes that all parties should agree to the creation of a structured, long term, cross-government National Reform Plan for Northern Ireland including measurable targets and agreed implementation dates.

Elements of a National Reform Plan for Northern Ireland could include:

- alternative models of service delivery such as increasing the use of social enterprises;
- a Civil Service Reform Plan;
- a more digital government;
- expanding shared services provision; and
- a dedicated Change Fund to stimulate reform.

2. A GOOD BUDGET SETTLEMENT

The DUP will fight hard at Westminster for a Budget settlement that allows for real terms increases in health and education spending over the next parliamentary term and will prioritise these areas in future Northern Ireland Budgets.

3. PROGRESSING HEALTH REFORMS

The DUP were in the driving seat in developing ambitious, far sighted reforms for our National Health Service in Northern Ireland. These reforms including the Bengoa Panel's recommendations for a new model of health and social care, and proposals to eliminate a layer of bureaucracy by abolishing the HSC Board are much needed. The DUP supports these reforms and wants to see them progressed as a matter of urgency. Similarly, our Health Service needs a properly resourced plan to reduce waiting lists and a dedicated Transformation Fund to support reform.

Health is fundamental to every person in Northern Ireland. The DUP will continue to strive for a situation where key decisions about the enhancement of the NHS in Northern Ireland are free from party politics.

4. GIVING EVERY CHILD THE CHANCE TO SUCCEED

The DUP is committed to defending and improving our education system in Northern Ireland to ensure that every child has the opportunity to succeed in life.

We will fight for sufficient resources to be provided for frontline schools budgets, and for greater autonomy in decision making for schools. We support academic selection, the maintenance of the Dickson Plan, and greater value being placed on vocational qualifications. We will focus on tackling educational underachievement through support for early years interventions, an expanded childcare strategy and community based initiatives. The DUP supports equality of treatment for all education sectors, including removal of discrimination in teacher employment, as well as increased shared education across all education sectors.

5. SAFER STREETS AND SMARTER JUSTICE

Maintaining law and order is one of government's primary duties. The DUP supports the justice family across the United Kingdom in the fight against crime in all its increasingly complex guises. The DUP supports:

- The adoption a 'Problem Solving' approach in our courts;
- A measure of protection for the Police in future Budgets;
- An increased focus on cyber crime;
- the introduction of a NI Register of Animal Cruelty Offenders and the seriousness of these animal cruelty offences reflected in the sentences handed down by courts;
- the PSNI in their efforts to target criminal gangs and ensure they have all the powers necessary to seize assets of paramilitary godfathers

5 Defending Our Nation from Old and New Threats

The DUP does not believe that the present defence arrangements for the United Kingdom are adequate enough to cope with the emerging threats in the 21st Century. We appreciate that in a time of significant challenge to public finances, almost all areas will be affected, but more consideration needs to be given to prioritising the funding of defence. In order to afford it some protection, the DUP supported the UK maintaining the NATO target of 2% of GDP for the Defence Budget, despite reservations about the funding formula.

However, it would be unwise to allow the present funding, strength and plans for our Armed Forces to become the accepted norm. History demonstrates that re-growing defence capability in times of national crisis is both disproportionately expensive and too late.

It should be remembered that the NATO target is intended as a minimum figure not a ceiling for Defence expenditure. There is also legitimacy to the charge that the UK has only maintained the 2% target through a new definition of Defence spending. In the next term, it is expected that the UK public finances should improve. When we achieve this we believe Defence should be one of the priorities for new investment.

Recent harrowing events in Manchester highlight the fact that the strategic threat of the Cold War escalating to a nuclear conflict has been replaced by a multiplicity of threats, both conventional and unconventional, and not just from states but also from trans-national groups of linked terror movements. This has triggered the emergence of a multitude of terrorist threats and precipitated the current migration crisis in Europe. Additionally, Jihadists returning to the United Kingdom represent a new and highly dangerous threat. This means the capabilities of our Defence and Intelligence infrastructure needs strengthened with a focus on the ability of our forces to deploy rapidly and to adapt to emerging threats.

We must not ignore dissident Republican terrorists and the threat they pose to all our citizens in Northern Ireland and Great Britain. The intelligence community and our security forces must be given a budget and rules of engagement that enable them not only to deter the threat from Republican splinter groups but also to actively pursue such terrorists and defeat them.

This is the DUP's Plan to strengthen the UK's Defences and support service personnel and veterans.

1. A NEW NATIONAL SECURITY AND STRATEGIC DEFENCE REVIEW

When the public finances improve we believe it will be appropriate to have a new National Security and Strategic Defence Review. The 2015 Review demonstrated a lack of strategic ambition and was too much a product of expenditure limitations. The DUP believes that such a review needs to be honest about the nature of the threats we face and the consequences of failing to deal with them. Only then can we make the difficult choices about capability and affordability.

In terms of military doctrine, we believe our military capability should be driven by the ability to act alone in defence of our own strategic interests in places like the Falkland Islands whilst also continuing to be the partner of choice to our allies, primarily through NATO. Within our military capabilities, the DUP believes the sufficient staffing, training and equipping of our reserve forces must be a priority.

2. MAINTAINING OUR INDEPENDENT NUCLEAR DETERRENT, AND NUCLEAR PROLIFERATION

The DUP has consistently supported the maintenance of the UK's independent nuclear deterrent and will continue to support Trident's renewal. One of the reasons for the need to renew is the systematic failure of the international community to deal with the issue of nuclear proliferation. We believe the UK should use all international forums to completely overhaul the approaches to counter proliferation and support efforts to prevent the likes of North Korean dictatorships from gaining and distributing such technology.

3. PLAYING A FULL ROLE IN INTERNATIONAL MILITARY AND SECURITY RELATIONSHIPS

The DUP supports our participation in NATO but shares the American concerns that other members are consistently failing to fulfil the minimum spending target. The Russian state is becoming more belligerent in its actions based on its assessment of western political and military weakness. This pattern of behaviour will only be arrested by a reversal of both of these weaknesses.

4. A CYBERSECURITY LEADER FOR THE UNITED KINGDOM

Cybersecurity is recognised as the current dominant threat to global security. Part of the growth of the knowledge economy in Northern Ireland has been a specialism in the area of cybersecurity. The DUP believes this is a critical area where Northern Ireland could contribute to countering this growing threat to national security. We support the expansion of cybersecurity research in Northern Ireland.

5. A REVIEW OF THE MILITARY COVENANT

Northern Ireland is part of the United Kingdom with both an immense contribution to our Armed Forces and debt to our Armed Forces for the protection they provided in the successful execution of Operation Banner. These are why fulfilling the Military Covenant is particularly important for us.

We believe that the Military Covenant should be reviewed and updated. The DUP supports the introduction of Independent Commissioners in the four parts of the United Kingdom to ensure the Covenant is fully implemented. The DUP is conscious how equality legislation in Northern Ireland has been used to hamper the fulfilment of both the spirit and the practical elements of the Covenant here. It wishes to see this situation ended and Veterans in Northern Ireland to be treated equally to Veterans right across the United Kingdom.

6. BRINGING ARMED FORCES DAY TO NORTHERN IRELAND

It is unacceptable that Northern Ireland has never hosted the main national event for Armed Forces Day in the UK. The DUP wish to see Northern Ireland host the main national event at some point in the life of the next Parliament and regularly thereafter.

7. A REVIEW OF THE PRESENT TERRORISM LEGISLATION

The DUP believes that considering the multi-faceted evolving and insidious nature of the terrorist threat it is time to review whether present arrangements need to be updated or upgraded.

This review should include:

- An updated legal framework for intelligence led anti-terrorism investigations and operations in the U.K.
- A UK wide definition of a victim which excludes perpetrators.
- Changes to the glorification of terrorism offences with an examination of the 20 year time limit.
- Consideration of intelligence and security committee membership representing all regions of the UK

8. RESISTING ATTEMPTS TO REWRITE THE PAST

Ninety percent of the deaths in the Troubles were by paramilitaries yet the balance of investigations is disproportionately against former police officers and soldiers. A one-sided approach only serves those who want to re-write the past.

It is only natural that the public are outraged to see former soldiers who stood against the brutal terrorism of the early seventies instigated by the IRA now being hounded while many of those who hid behind balaclavas avoid justice.

The recent Defence Select Committee's report "Investigation into Fatalities in Northern Ireland involving British Personnel" recommends Government bring forward a statute of limitations, following a DUP led debate in Parliament. The DUP also managed to secure Committee backing to extend such a proposal to include members of the Royal Ulster Constabulary and other security personnel.

The last twenty years have been marred by the completely imbalanced treatment of those who terrorised our society compared against brave service personnel who ensured they would never succeed. Early release of prisoners, a maximum two year sentence for fresh terrorist convictions, odious On the Run legislation and a secretive scheme to issue letters of immunity have all tarnished the process of justice.

Our troubled past can only be dealt with effectively in an honest and holistic manner, not the partial way republicans would wish. We must ensure that the past cannot be rewritten. Government should go ahead and publish their draft legislation so the new Historical Investigations Unit can commence its work as soon as possible. We will do everything we can to assist innocent victims to obtain a measure of justice.

6 Getting the Best Deal for Northern Ireland from the UK leaving the EU

WHY WE SUPPORTED A VOTE TO LEAVE: The DUP's decision to support leaving the European Union was based on principle and practicality. The DUP had opposed joining in the first place, had been consistent in its scepticism throughout our membership and fully supported the question of membership being put to the people of the United Kingdom. This was the demonstration of our commitment to principle.

In terms of practicality when the then Prime Minister David Cameron attempted to achieve tangible reform of the European Union we supported this initiative. In our previous Westminster manifesto the DUP stated:

"We support the current UK Government pledge to renegotiate elements of our relationship with the European Union."

The deafness of the EU institutions to change in those negotiations meant that this process did not deliver the fundamental reform the EU required. Therefore, with no reasonable alternative available, the DUP chose to maintain its stance and advocate for a leave vote.

Some would seek to make this a re-run of last year's referendum. Our job now is not to refight old battles but to use our mandate and our influence to get the best deal for Northern Ireland.

The United Kingdom's departure from the European Union inevitably brings with it opportunities as well as challenges.

Whichever way people voted in the referendum last June, and whatever concerns they may still have we can all unite to ensure Northern Ireland's interests are promoted.

For our part we will work to get the best deal for Northern Ireland, recognizing that we share a land frontier with the Republic and the particular circumstances of our unique history and geography.

The circumstances of Northern Ireland are well understood and working together sensibly we have the opportunity to secure a good outcome that delivers for everyone.

In the new Parliament, Northern Ireland needs to have a strong, united DUP team arguing the case for our people.

DURING THE NEGOTIATIONS THE DUP WANTS TO SEE A FOCUS ON THE FOLLOWING PRIORITIES AND OBJECTIVES:

1. Successful outward-looking knowledge-based economy in Northern Ireland
2. Ease of trade with the Irish Republic and throughout the European Union
3. Maintenance of the Common Travel Area
4. Strengthened relationships across the four components parts of the United Kingdom with no internal borders
5. Northern Ireland-specific solutions achieved through active Executive engagement
6. Particular circumstances of Northern Ireland with a land border with the EU fully reflected
7. Frictionless border with Irish Republic assisting those working or travelling in the other jurisdiction
8. Progress on new free trade deals with the rest of the world
9. Comprehensive free trade and customs agreement with the European Union
10. Northern Ireland established as a hub for trade from Irish Republic into the broader UK market
11. Customs arrangements which facilitate trade with new and existing markets
12. Confidence and capacity within local businesses to maximize opportunities
13. Business to retain competitiveness and not face additional costs
14. Arrangements to facilitate ease of movement of people, goods and services
15. Proportionate regulatory regime which can promote competitiveness, with legislation to suit our local needs
16. Local input into new UK agriculture and fisheries policies which can offer sustainability and new growth opportunities
17. Particular importance of agri-food sector to Northern Ireland economy recognised and reflected
18. Strong protections for agri-food to guard against vulnerabilities to cheap inferior imports
19. An appropriate support programme for our farmers should continue after we leave
20. Effective immigration policy which meets the skills, labour and security needs of the UK
21. Rights of British citizens in the EU and those from EU member states living here safeguarded
22. Energy market stability
23. Effective, time bound transitional arrangements where necessary
24. Higher and further education continuing to attract international expertise and collaboration
25. Ability to opt-in to EU funds where proven to be cost-effective and add value
26. Continued participation in funding programmes that have been proven to be of benefit and are open to non-EU members e.g. research funding
27. Fair share for Northern Ireland from dividends from leaving the EU
28. UK wide skills and infrastructure funds should be established to lead with an emphasis on regional specialisations
29. Jurisdiction of European Court of Justice ended and greater control over our laws restored
30. Positive ongoing relationship with European Union in keeping with Article 8 of Lisbon Treaty.

It is in the interests of all in Northern Ireland that the UK-EU negotiations progress well and that the trade elements commence as soon as possible. The stronger and more positive the agreements reached, especially on trade and customs relationships, then the better for the particular circumstances of Northern Ireland

7 A Real Respect Agenda

The role and importance of identity is an increasing issue of discussion across the Western world. The development and impact of globalisation had led many to assume that identity was inexorably fading away. This is not true. The desire to be from somewhere remains inherent in many and played an important role across many recent elections. Simply put, identity matters.

In a Northern Ireland context, the DUP Leader Arlene Foster has commenced an ongoing process of engagement around how identity is treated in Northern Ireland. The aim of this is to develop a real respect agenda on the issue of identity here.

Respect does not mean simply acceding to everything asked for or demanded by different groups or communities. Instead, it is a dialogue of what is wanted, what is needed and what can be practically delivered to ensure the expression of an identity and its successful communication to the next generation. In this dialogue, an important place must be made for our growing minority ethnic communities to ensure their contribution to our diversity and to integrate into our society.

While the desires of the Irish language community have been highlighted it would be a mistake to assume that this means there is contentment with the present identity settlement amongst the variety of cultural expressions in Northern Ireland. The commentary and manifestation of disrespect is not exclusive to one identity or one form of expression. An obvious example is the continuing targeting of Orange Halls for physical attack while political parties, with cheerleading from sections of the media, attack any public funds going to them.

In the spirit of contributing to a genuine discussion and development of a real respect agenda the DUP would see a number of areas of concern that need to be addressed. The DUP believes these reflect the identity concerns of different cross-sections of those who support Unionism and in some cases beyond it. It does not claim to be exhaustive or prescriptive for all different identities here but to contribute to the discussion and development of a real respect agenda.

These concerns fit within three broad categories:

- Our British Identity
- Our Ulster Identities
- Our Pride in Northern Ireland

OUR BRITISH IDENTITY

Within this context there are four broad areas where progress is sought. These include:

1. British Symbols

For significant periods of recent history, there has been a consistent attempt to reduce the display of British symbols. This process was particularly aggressive in Northern Ireland. It was commonly referred to as “hollowing out Ulster’s Britishness” but the process was not exclusive to Northern Ireland.

More recent times have shown a greater desire to display national symbols in the public realm and greater embracing of Britishness. Northern Ireland has been excluded from this process. For example, Northern Ireland’s flag legislation has seen a consistent reduction in days while Nationalist ministers blocked a simple measure like the Union flag on driving licences, rejecting even an opt-in option.

Therefore, there is a clear desire that this exclusion of Northern Ireland from these positive developments for the public expression of Britishness ends.

2. National Celebration and Commemoration

The celebration and commemoration of important national events are central to the maintenance and promotion of a common identity. The full enjoyment, celebration and/or participation in them needs to be guaranteed. Examples of how this has not been occurring are Homecoming parades, the Armed Forces Day National event and the Battlefield Tours programme. There were demonstrations against Homecoming parades. Northern Ireland has never hosted the main national event for Armed Forces Day, unlike every other constituent part of the UK. Schools from Northern Ireland have only just started participating on a pilot basis in WW1 Battlefield tours. These commenced elsewhere in the UK in 2014 and NI’s exclusion was the result of Sinn Féin’s control of the education and cultural ministries.

3. Recognition and Support of Military Service

Our Armed Forces, their sacrifices and their achievements are a central and continuing bond. The debt that is owed to these men and women is expressed through the Military Covenant. The inequality that sees veterans in Northern Ireland not enjoying the full benefits of this covenant is not something that the DUP considers in any way acceptable. Thus, a framework to:

- ensure its complete fulfilment;
 - support research on veterans’ needs and acting on its recommendations; and
 - proper structures with ongoing oversight,
- is required.

Likewise, to encourage our future contribution to the military our Cadet services in Northern Ireland should receive comparable support arrangements as elsewhere in UK and the development of a new Army Museum in Northern Ireland should be seen as an opportunity for significant development.

4. The Commonwealth

Our membership of the EU meant the Commonwealth and its contribution was often overlooked. Its peoples have contributed so much to the diversity of modern Britain and is an international network we must utilise better at pursuing our mutual interests. The role and contribution of the Commonwealth should be better promoted in our schools. Northern Ireland should seek to host Commonwealth political and sporting events and maximise the range of sports in which Northern Ireland teams participate.

Beyond these themes the DUP would also like to see the development of a UK equivalent of Co-operation Ireland promoting the linkages across the constituent parts of the country.

OUR ULSTER IDENTITIES

The Ulster-Scots heritage, language and culture and Orangeism have both made a huge contribution to our own local identity as well as having a significant impact beyond our shores. However, their birth and strength remain here.

1. Ulster-Scots heritage, language and culture

When you consider the breadth and depth of the Ulster-Scots identity the range of measures and opportunities that could be pursued is long. At its core there must be reform and resourcing of the Ulster-Scots Agency, refocusing of the Ulster-Scots Broadcast Fund and fulfilling the 2003 promise to create an Ulster-Scots Academy. These developments would facilitate the likes of language promotion, tourism initiatives, capital investment, cultural networks, diaspora development, social economy projects, inclusion in the education system and bespoke courses, academic research and digital and broadcasting growth.

2. Orangeism

It is a continuing contradiction that despite all the talk of rights in Northern Ireland many of the same people are silent about or opposed to freedom of assembly. Public expression by parades is central to Orangeism but over the years regardless of who was on the Parades Commissions the end result has been the same. Namely, the exclusion of Orangeism from ever greater areas of public space. This is regardless of engagement or not or compliance or not and often rewarded violence. Thus the DUP is committed to a new start on parades.

OUR PRIDE IN NORTHERN IRELAND

The pride in Northern Ireland that many feel in what we can achieve together or individually is something the DUP wishes to promote and believes would be attractive to a broad cross-section of people in Northern Ireland. This would include:

1. Celebration of Northern Ireland's Centenary

Despite an agreement of Executive support for the 'Decade of Centenaries', this led to little practical action. The DUP does not want that to be the case in 2021. It will be a clear opportunity for us to celebrate what has been achieved in the previous 100 years but equally to look forward to what we want to achieve in the next century.

The programme for this should include a public holiday, public art, an 'Expo', centenary wood and greenway, securing of major sporting events and practical measures to demonstrate our values such as 'baby boxes' and awards for centenarians.

2. Recognition of Northern Ireland

The recognition of Northern Ireland can be given practical effect in a number of ways, for example:

- Within our museums, a narrative of a global, positive and innovative Northern Ireland that achieved economic success and is dedicated to regaining such a position again;
- Recognition for the symbols associated with Northern Ireland; and
- Recognition of Northern Ireland sporting bodies, the Olympic team should be referred to as Team UK and the freedom for athletes to choose their national team.

Standing up for Unionism, Speaking up for Northern Ireland

Sinn Fein have used their mandate at the last Assembly election to demand a destabilising Border Poll, to push a republican agenda and to block the re-establishment of the Assembly. It's time for unionists to come out and vote so the real voice of Northern Ireland is heard.

A vote for the DUP is a vote ...

- ✓ For Northern Ireland's place within the United Kingdom
- ✓ For real influence at Westminster
- ✓ For the best deal for Northern Ireland as the UK leaves the EU
- ✓ For the strongest representation at Westminster
- ✓ For the restoration of the Assembly and Executive

If you want the DUP to be Northern Ireland's voice at Westminster so we can stand up for unionism, speak up for Northern Ireland, and stop Gerry Adams and Sinn Fein from dictating the political agenda, then you must send that message by voting for the DUP.



Use your vote to unite around the biggest
and strongest unionist party. Vote DUP!



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[@duonline](https://twitter.com/duonline)

Contact us:

DUP Headquarters

91 Dundela Avenue,

Belfast, BT4 3BU

T: (028) 9047 1155

E: info@mydup.com

